

“Those regions which we found and explored with the fleet ... we may rightly call a New World.

Amerigo Vespucci, 1503”

Several factors contributed to Cortés' and Pizarro's astounding conquests. The Aztecs were overwhelmed by a kind of battle unknown to them, involving firearms and the single-minded slaughter of opponents—Aztec practice was to capture prisoners, whom they would later kill in ritual sacrifice. The Spanish were also helped by alliances they made with local peoples who were hostile to the Aztecs. The result for Spain was a flow of wealth across the Atlantic and a secure base for building on their involvement in the Americas.

Further Spanish colonization followed, including that of Colombia, known to the Spanish as New Granada. By the end of the 17th century, much of western and central South America was in Spanish hands. Conquered areas, and the people who lived in them, were parceled out to the Spanish conquistadors, who undertook to convert the locals to Christianity. They did convert them, but they also made them perform forced labor, especially in the silver mines. Laborers fell victim to disease and exploitation—like their counterparts in Brazil, but on a lesser scale—and enslaved people from Africa were brought in to supplement their numbers.

The Spanish Crown tried to control this large empire, appointing viceroys to rule over the settlers and the native American

The siege of Tenochtitlan, the Aztec capital, was decisive in the Spanish conquest of Mexico, and brought the Spaniards a step closer to their goal of colonizing the Americas.

